TOPIC REPORTS: DIGITAL DIVIDES

GOVERNANCE · FINANCE · ICT INFRASTRUCTURE · DPI · DIGITALISATION · TECHNOLOGY · CAPACITY · INCLUSION · DATA · GEOPOLITICS

News, Sep – Oct 2026

ACCESS TO SERVICES · DIGITAL DIVIDES

Angola · Cape Verde · Chad · DR Congo · Egypt · Eswatini · Gambia · Ghana · Guinea-Bissau · Kenya · Madagascar · Morocco · Nigeria · Rwanda · Somalia · South Africa · Tanzania · Uganda · Zambia

Angola

CONECTA ANGOLA SATELLITE CONNECTIVITY POINTS

- **Sistema de Internet em Madimba e Serra da Kanda volta a funcionar** — Angop (Angola Press Agency), 6 September 2026

  Two Conecta Angola satellite internet points at Madimba and Serra da Kanda in Zaire province, installed in 2024 and linked through Angosat-2, were restored after battery and software faults, Angola's national space programme office said. About 1,400 residents use them free of charge, and further points and school routers are planned in the province.

Cape Verde

BENDI MAX DIGITAL INCLUSION PILOT FOR WOMEN TRADERS

- **Maio: Projecto 'Bendi Max' arranca em Outubro para reforçar inclusão digital de mulheres comerciantes** — Inforpress, 19 September 2026

  Bendi Max, a pilot to train 250 women traders in Cabo Verde to use digital tools in their businesses, starts on Maio island in October 2026 with 30 participants, Inforpress reported on 19 September. It then extends to Fogo, Santiago and São Vicente, with the economy ministry, Pró-Empresa, Cabo Verde Digital and the United Nations as partners.

Chad

COMMUNITY MULTIMEDIA CENTRES UNDER THE UNIVERSAL SERVICE PROGRAMME

- **Moundou : l'ADETIC inaugure un Centre communautaire multimédia pour renforcer l'inclusion numérique** — Le N'Djam Post, 29 September 2026

  Chad's ICT development agency inaugurated a community multimedia centre in Moundou under the universal service programme, with a training room and a cybercafe on grid, solar and generator power.

DR Congo

LOW-TECHNOLOGY REMOTE LEARNING IN EBOLA HIGH-RISK AREAS

- **Année scolaire 2026-2027 : Une reprise effective des cours sur toute l'étendue du territoire national malgré les défis sécuritaires et sanitaires** — MINEDU-NC RDC, 3 September 2026

The Democratic Republic of the Congo's education ministry reported that classes resumed on 1 September 2026 in all 60 educational provinces. In 18 sub-divisions classed as high risk for Ebola, the education and health ministries are providing distance learning through worksheets and radio or television broadcasts, designed so families need no internet access or digital equipment.

UNIVERSAL SERVICE FUND PILOT SITES

- **Connectivité : la RDC explore des solutions abordables pour étendre le réseau** — Agence Ecofin, 13 October 2026

  DR Congo's posts and telecommunications ministry is promoting solar-powered microsites to extend mobile coverage to rural and peri-urban areas, presented to the universal service fund and four operators. Fifty pilot sites are planned, each said to cost a quarter of a conventional mast.

Egypt

PRESIDENTIAL INITIATIVE ON DIGITAL ACCESSIBILITY OF GOVERNMENT WEBSITES

- **وزارة النقل تطلق خدمة الإتاحة الرقمية لذوي الهمم عبر موقعها الإلكتروني** — اليوم السابع (Youm7), 17 September 2026

  Egypt's Ministry of Transport added accessibility tools for people with disabilities to its website, mot.gov.eg, reported on 17 September 2026, working with the ICT ministry and the National Academy of IT for Persons with Disabilities. The tools include text-to-speech, speech-to-text, a sign-language interpreter, dyslexia fonts and a reading mask; the ministry plans to extend them to its affiliated bodies' sites.

ICT INCLUSION PLAYBOOK FOR PERSONS WITH DISABILITIES

- **ITIDA, GIZ launch ICT Inclusion Playbook to advance disability inclusion** — Egyptian Gazette, 26 September 2026

  Egypt's Information Technology Industry Development Agency and GIZ Egypt launched an initiative in which 14 ICT companies, including IBM, Microsoft, DXC and Orange Business, will co-develop a playbook for recruiting and including persons with disabilities. The consultancy Fit For Life will run 15 workshops and sessions. No funding figure is given.

- **ITIDA, GIZ launch ICT inclusion playbook in Egypt** — Amwal Al Ghad, 28 September 2026

  Egypt's IT industry development agency and GIZ launched work with 14 ICT companies on a playbook for recruiting and including persons with disabilities, to be produced through 15 workshops and published on the agency's website.

Eswatini

SMART AFRICA GENDER IMPACT ASSESSMENT TOOLS FOR DIGITAL POLICY

- **SMART AFRICA TO TEST GENDER IMPACT TOOLS IN ESWATINI** — Eswatini Positive News, 5 October 2026

  Eswatini's ICT ministry is validating three gender impact assessment tools ahead of a Smart Africa workshop in Mbabane from 6 to 8 October 2026, where participants will adapt and pilot them for local digital development programmes. The article does not describe what the tools measure.

- **Gender checks proposed for digital policies** — Times of Eswatini, 7 October 2026 GAMBIA

  Eswatini's ICT minister, opening the gender impact assessment workshop in Mbabane, said the government wants such assessments built into digital policies and programmes before they are implemented.

- **Gender impact tool targets the digital divide facing women** — FinGuard Magazine, 7 October 2026 GAMBIA

A magazine account of the same Eswatini pilot of Smart Africa's gender impact assessment framework, which is meant to test whether digital programmes narrow the divide facing women. It names the tools differently from the ministry's account.

- **Minister Savannah vows to continue advocating for women In tech** — Independent News Eswatini, 7 October 2026 GAMBIA

  Eswatini's ICT ministry and Smart Africa opened a workshop on 7 October to develop and pilot gender impact assessment tools for digital policy, with Eswatini and The Gambia as pilot countries. Three instruments are to be tested on selected digital policies before validation.

Gambia

SMART AFRICA GENDER IMPACT ASSESSMENT TOOLS FOR DIGITAL POLICY

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Ghana

RURAL TELEPHONY AND DIGITAL INCLUSION PROJECT

- **Gov't to upgrade all rural telephony networks to 4G capability – Sam George** — MyJoyOnline (GNA), 5 September 2026

  Ghana's communications minister, Samuel Nartey George, said on 5 September 2026 that every Rural Telephony Project site will be upgraded to at least 4G, and that about 1,400 of the planned 2,016 sites are live. GIFEC's rural telephony allocation this year is about GH¢30 million. MTN Ghana is adding 800 sites this year and Telecel Ghana about 350.

- **Sam George inspects Rural Telephony projects to boost mobile network connectivity in Eastern Region** — News Alert Ghana, 6 September 2026

  Ghana's Communications Minister Samuel Nartey George inspected rural telephony sites in the Eastern Region on 4 September 2026 and directed that all rural telephony sites nationwide be upgraded to at least 4G. He said rural communities are still being given 2G and 3G. No cost or timetable for the upgrade is given.

- **NPP challenges Sam George over rural telephony record, demands data** — MyJoyOnline, 8 September 2026

Ghana's opposition New Patriotic Party said on 8 September 2026 that the Ghana Rural Telephony and Digital Inclusion Project began in 2020, financed by a EUR155 million China EXIM Bank facility, and left 1,961 sites built by January 2025. It called on the communications ministry and GIFEC to publish a full status report on the project within 30 days.

- **NPP gives Communications Ministry 30 days to disclose rural telephony status** — Citi Newsroom, 8 September 2026

  Ghana's opposition gave the communications ministry 30 days to publish a full status report on the Rural Telephony and Digital Inclusion Project, asking for sites constructed, connected, operational and built but out of service. The project runs on a EUR155 million China Eximbank facility against a target of 2,016 sites, with 1,961 stated as constructed at the January 2025 handover and 46 disputed as unconnectable.

- **Ghana Directs GIFEC to Expand Rural Connectivity and Accelerate Network Upgrades** — Tech Africa News, 14 October 2026

  After inspecting rural telephony sites on 13 October, Ghana's communications minister directed GIFEC to extend service to three more communities in Sekyere Afram Plains. The government is also working with MTN Ghana on 800 new sites at locations proposed by MPs.

- **Government to audit 2,016 community network sites – Communications Minister** — MyJoyOnline, 14 October 2026

  Ghana's communications minister Samuel Nartey George said the government will commission an independent audit of 2,016 community network sites inherited under an existing contract, to establish which are complete and working. He made the statement after inspecting four solar-powered rural telephony sites in Sekyere Afram Plains District on 13 October, which he said should be upgraded from 3G to 4G.

- **Sam George gives contractors 30 days to finish rural telephony sites or face penalties** — Adom Online, 17 October 2026

  Ghana's communications minister Sam George gave Rural Telephony Project contractors 30 days to finish outstanding sites or face penalties, saying they have been paid in full, after touring sites in the Volta Region. He also said Ghana recorded more than 4,000 fibre cuts by June 2026 and operators spent over $20 million on fibre repairs in 2025.

231 TOLL-FREE VOICE INFORMATION LINE

- **Viamo Launches 231 Voice Platform in Ghana, Creating a New National Channel for Inclusive Communication and Offline AI** — Ghanamma, 10 September 2026

  Viamo, a Canadian digital non-profit, launched 231, a toll-free voice service in Ghana built with MTN. Callers on any basic phone can put spoken questions to its offline AI assistant in Twi, Ewe, Hausa, Dagbani, Ga or English without data or an app. Ghana is Viamo's fourth such MTN platform after Liberia, Zambia and Rwanda.

Guinea-Bissau

ADOLESCENT ACCESS TO A COMPUTER AND THE INTERNET

- **COVID-19 exposed the global digital divide among adolescents in Guinea-Bissau** — University of Iceland, 3 September 2026

  A University of Iceland doctoral study surveyed 2,039 teenagers aged 14–19 at 12 state and four private schools in Bissau. Researcher Fatou N'dure Baboudóttir found access to computers and the internet limited, especially for girls and state-school pupils, a divide she says the COVID-19 pandemic exposed further.

- **Birtingarmyndir ójafnaðar meðal unglinga í Bissá, Gíneu-Bissá (Manifestations of inequality among adolescents in Bissau, Guinea-Bissau)** — Opin vísindi (University of Iceland repository), 2026

  A University of Iceland doctoral thesis on inequality among adolescents in Bissau draws on a survey of 2,039 pupils aged 14 to 19 in 16 schools, followed by interviews and focus groups. It finds parental education and income decide access to private schooling, and that access to computers and the internet is limited, more so for girls and public-school pupils.

Kenya

PAY-AS-YOU-GO SMARTPHONE FINANCING MARKET

- **Sun King joins Kenya's growing smartphone financing race** — TechCabal, 4 September 2026

  Sun King began selling financed smartphones in Kenya, entering the market M-KOPA and Watu built. Its handset is sold only on a pay-as-you-go contract - a KES 2,299 deposit and KES 55 a day for 365 days, KES 22,374 in all - repaid through the phone's own lock screen, app, SIM toolkit or USSD, with the device locked if payments stop. The company opened a Tatu City assembly plant with capacity for 700,000 units a year in October 2025.

DIGITAL SKILLS PROGRAMME FOR REFUGEE AND HOST-COMMUNITY YOUTH, GARISSA AND TURKANA

- **Garissa Refugee Youth Get Digital Skills Training** — CIO Africa, 11 September 2026

  Power Learn Project, the ILO, Microsoft and Garissa County Government marked the Garissa rollout of a 25-week digital skills and employment programme for refugee and host-community youth, funded by the Netherlands under the PROSPECTS Partnership. It targets 1,700 young people in Garissa and Turkana; over 700 have enrolled in Garissa, and Microsoft is providing up to 1,000 certification vouchers.

- **Kenya: 1,700 Youth in Garissa, Turkana to Get Digital Skills Training** — Capital FM (Nairobi), via allAfrica.com, 11 September 2026

  About 1,700 young people from refugee and host communities in Kenya's Garissa and Turkana counties are to receive 25 weeks of training in AI, cloud computing and data analytics. Power Learn Project runs it with the ILO, Microsoft and Garissa County, funded by the Netherlands; over 700 have enrolled in Garissa and 16 of 37 hubs have begun. No funding sum is given.

- **Power Learn Project Trains 1,700 Youth in Kenya AI, Cloud Skills** — TechMoran, 11 September 2026

  Power Learn Project is training 1,700 young people from refugee and host communities in Kenya's Garissa and Turkana counties in AI, cloud computing and data analytics over 25 weeks. Backed by the ILO, Microsoft and Garissa County and funded by the Netherlands, it has enrolled more than 700 learners in Garissa; women make up 35% of applicants. No funding amount is given.

Madagascar

TELECOMS AND ICT DEVELOPMENT FUND (FDTIC)

- **Madagascar — Fonds de Développement des Télécommunications et des TIC (FDTIC) — états financiers, période du 1er janvier au 31 décembre 2024** — Autorité de Régulation des Technologies de Communication (ARTEC), for the FDTIC (Ministère du Développement Numérique, des Postes et des Télécommunications), 1 September 2026

Madagascar's telecoms regulator ARTEC published the 2024 financial statements of the Telecommunications and ICT Development Fund, the universal-service fund it manages. The four-page statements show Ar 62.9bn in contributions received, Ar 91.3bn granted and a deficit of Ar 27.95bn for the year. Whether an auditor's opinion accompanies them is not stated.

- **Madagascar — Fonds de Développement des Télécommunications et des TIC (FDTIC) — états financiers, période du 1er janvier au 31 décembre 2025** — Autorité de Régulation des Technologies de Communication (ARTEC), for the FDTIC (Ministère du Développement Numérique, des Postes et des Télécommunications), 1 September 2026

  Madagascar's telecoms and ICT development fund (FDTIC), the universal-service fund managed by the regulator ARTEC, published its financial statements for 1 January to 31 December 2025. The fund took in Ar 100.1 billion in contributions and granted Ar 100.4 billion, close to break-even after a 2024 deficit. The file does not show whether an auditor's opinion accompanies the four pages of statements.

Morocco

NIGHT-TIME NETWORK OUTAGES IN THE BEN CHERRO DOUARS, BENI MELLAL

- **(AR) Phone network cut at night in Ben Cherro douars, Beni Mellal: residents complain of a 'digital isolation' lasting until morning** — Al Omk Al Maghribi, 17 September 2026

  Residents of thirteen douars in the Ben Cherro area of Morocco's Beni Mellal province say phone service cuts out nightly from about 8pm until morning, with internet throughput degraded over the same hours. They describe the consequences as sharpest in emergencies.

Nigeria

NATIONAL STRATEGY FOR COMMUNITY-CENTRED CONNECTIVITY INITIATIVES 2025-2027

- **From strategy to action: Nigeria's communities push to bridge the digital divide** — Association for Progressive Communications (APC), 24 September 2026

  The Association for Progressive Communications reported on 24 September 2026 that Nigeria's National Strategy for Community-Centred Connectivity Initiatives, running to March 2027, is moving into implementation. Regulators estimate more than 100,000 communities may be eligible for support, and an aggregator licensing model is under study. A first community connectivity bootcamp was held in Abuja from 28 September to 2 October.

Rwanda

PROJECTED EFFECT OF AFFORDABILITY AND SKILLS REFORMS ON MOBILE INTERNET USE

- **Digital Reforms Could Connect Over 1 Million More People to Mobile Internet in Rwanda, GSMA Finds** — GSMA, 17 September 2026

  A GSMA report projects that more than a million additional people in Rwanda could be using mobile internet by 2031 if smartphones are made more affordable and digital services more relevant to everyday life. It names lower-income and rural households as the group the reforms would reach.

GENDANA KONTI WOMEN'S MOBILE-FINANCE CAMPAIGN

- **Abagore barenga 600,000 batangiye gukoresha serivisi z'imari kuri telefoni nyuma yo kumenya ibanga ryayo - Gate of Wise** — Gate of Wise, 27 September 2026

> The National Bank of Rwanda's governor, Soraya Hakuziyaremye, said 615,000 women had been brought into mobile financial services under the Gendana Konti campaign, against a target of 150,000, as the campaign closed. More than 200,000 of them opened mobile money accounts for the first time. Begun in 2023 in Nyaruguru and Nyamasheke districts, the campaign later expanded to other districts.

Somalia

> SMARTPHONE FINANCING PROGRAMME

- **Hormuud and GetPhone expand smartphone finance into four new Somali states due to high demand** — Soko Directory, 25 September 2026

  Hormuud Telecom and GetPhone said their smartphone financing programme in Somalia has sold more than 2,500 phones since its launch in May 2026 and is expanding through 15 more branches in Jubaland, South West, Hirshabelle and Galmudug. In nearly 1,700 contracts signed in August, borrowers with credit scores under 500 had repaid 89.7% of amounts due, against 90.5% for those scoring 650 or above.

South Africa

> ADULTS SHOPPING ONLINE

- **South Africa Online Shopping Lags Internet Access as Retail Market Targets Wider Adoption** — Tech Africa News, 21 September 2026

  The Online Retail in South Africa 2026 report finds 79.1% of adults online but only 34.2% shopping online in 2025, down from 36.6% in 2024, while online retail turnover rose to about R130 billion. The gap is widest among lower-income consumers and women. Delivery costs, weak last-mile service outside the cities and worries about payment security are named as barriers.

Tanzania

> UNIVERSAL SERVICE FUND SCHOOL ICT LABORATORIES

- **UCSAF to construct 250 ICT laboratories in public schools** — Universal Communications Service Access Fund (UCSAF), 6 October 2026

  Tanzania's Universal Communications Service Access Fund said on 5 October 2026 it will build 250 ICT laboratories of 20 computers each in public schools this financial year, instead of its earlier provision of about five computers per school. It reports more than 1,121 schools equipped so far and 2,166 subsidised towers completed in 2,306 wards.

Uganda

> OYAM RURAL COMMUNITY BROADBAND NETWORK

- **Free internet access excites traders in Oyam market** — The Observer (Uganda), 14 September 2026

  A rural community broadband network built by the Women of Uganda Network with netLabs!UG and the Internet Society Foundation is in technical testing at 12 sites in Uganda's Oyam district. Market traders already use it instead of buying mobile data; one vendor put her former spend at about Shs5,000 a day. More than 60 people have received digital literacy training.

Zambia

> CONNECTIVITY AND DIGITAL LEARNING PROGRAMME FOR PUBLIC SCHOOLS

- **70 Zambian Public Schools to Receive Starlink Connectivity Under Three-Year Programme** — Efficacy News, 18 September 2026

  Zambia launched a three-year programme to connect an initial 70 public schools by satellite, with solar power for schools off the grid, run by the presidential delivery unit with private partners. No cost or school list is stated.

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